

format requiring teams to execute a driver swap during a pit stop to complete the two-leg contest.

The Briton's opening stint saw him build a strong lead before handing over to teammate Fabienne Wohlwend, who managed the second leg and steered the car to the finish. She became only the second female driver to win an IRL race, an added reward to a memorable home weekend for the team.

Challenges beyond the racing line

The sessions produced entertaining action but were not without hitches, both on and off the makeshift circuit. The red soil, though visually striking, made track conditions tricky, reducing grip and contributing to lock-ups and slides. Barring the occasional Safety Car and track clearances, there weren't any major incidents.

An unexpected challenge was a dry-grass fire on nearby cleared land. Thick smoke rose behind the fan lounge, while shifting winds carried soot through the air and made efforts to put out the fire difficult. Event officials said precautionary measures were already in place to keep the flames from reaching the

tents. Such interruptions, even unusual ones, are not uncommon for an event that requires extensive planning, heavy investment, multiple permissions and coordination across civic bodies — an undertaking as complex off track as the racing on it.

That reality was echoed by former India cricketer Sourav Ganguly, who is also an IRL team owner. "It's not easy organising such a big event. We organise cricket matches in stadiums, which are dedicated areas. But to come into a city and create such infrastructure and try to make something happen is absolutely special. Motorsport around the world is big, but it's a very young sport in India. It needs a bit of patience, it needs a bit of support," he said.

Building something bigger

The broader objective remained clear. Street races like this are intended to build visibility for Indian

Urban spectacle: Street races like this are intended to build visibility for Indian motorsport by bringing competition directly into public spaces. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

motorsport by bringing competition directly into public spaces. Celebrity team owners and guests added to the atmosphere, while the sound of engines proved a draw in itself.

By the end of the weekend, the Goa round had done what it set out to do: show that the concept can travel, adapt and function beyond a single city. It may not have drawn the largest crowd or produced the loudest spectacle, but it demonstrated progress.

That momentum now carries into the title-deciding round in Navi Mumbai this March — another street circuit and a test of whether the series can sustain that growth. For a championship still establishing its footprint, continuity may matter as much as results.

The writer was at the event on invitation by Indian Racing Festival

